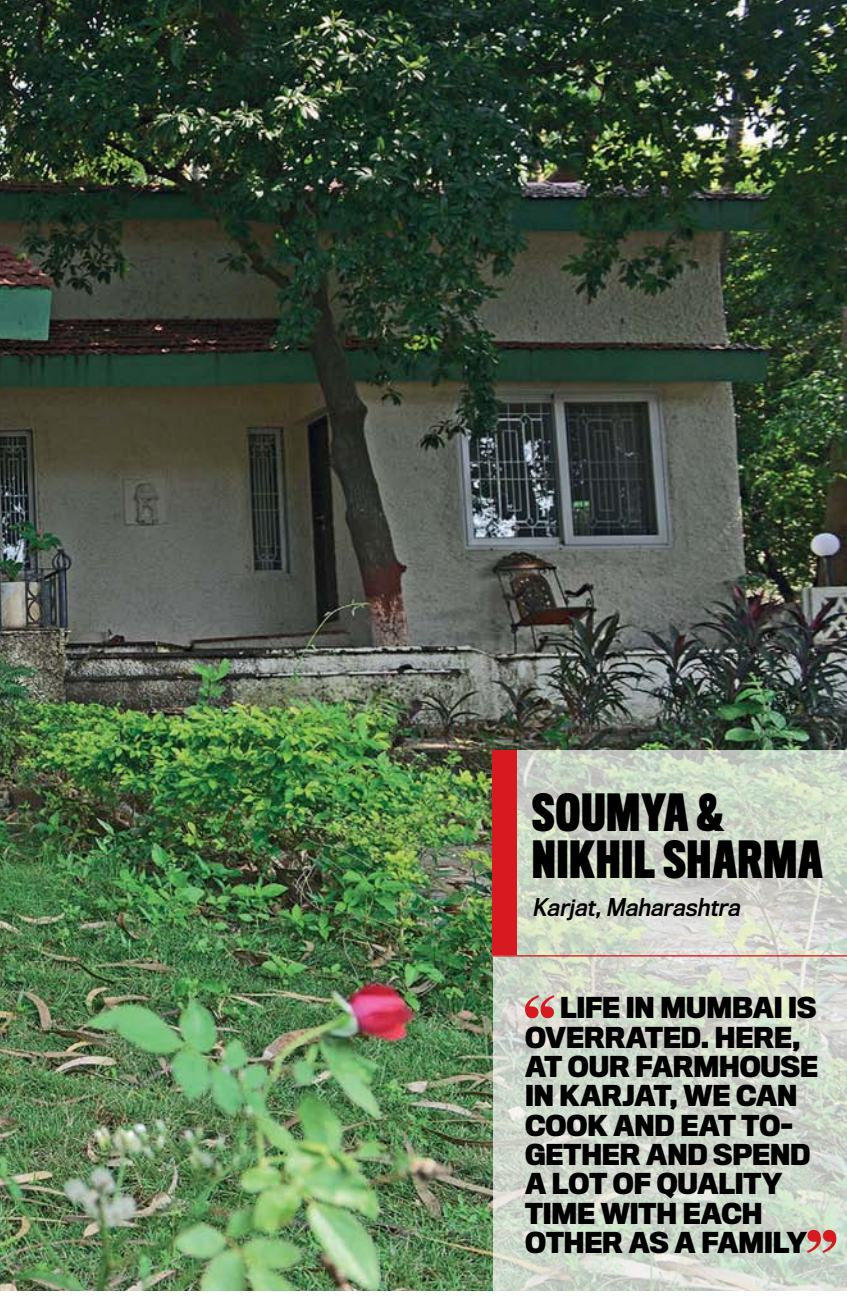


SOUMYA & NIKHIL SHARMA

Karjat, Maharashtra

"LIFE IN MUMBAI IS OVERRATED. HERE, AT OUR FARMHOUSE IN KARJAT, WE CAN COOK AND EAT TOGETHER AND SPEND A LOT OF QUALITY TIME WITH EACH OTHER AS A FAMILY"

MANDAR DEODHAR

A few weeks after the Covid-induced lockdown was announced in March 2020, Soumya Sharma, 27, and her family of five decided to spend a few days at their spacious farmhouse in Karjat, located barely 65 km from Mumbai. That plan of 'few days' kept getting extended until the family realised that they were happier living on the farm rather than in the city. However, Sharma's job as a news analyst needed her to go 'on air' from home and the farmhouse didn't have good internet connectivity. But a good wi-fi connection fixed this small hurdle and the young couple started working from their farmhouse. "We started enjoying this life. There's a river running across our property and it was lovely to walk around and soak in the clean, crisp air after work, something we don't get in Mumbai," says Sharma.

Now, the family goes to the local supermarket every few days to stock up on provisions and make a trip to Mumbai usually once a week for work. "But we have shifted our base to Karjat. From being our second home, the farmhouse has become our first home," says Sharma, adding that the family doesn't feel like it's missing out on anything. "Mumbai is highly overrated. Here, we can cook and eat together and spend a lot of quality time with each other as a family," she says. The shift "back to the basics" has been refreshing. "Covid has made us realise that it is the small things that give us a lot more happiness," she says.

Like the Sharma clan, many families are increasingly spending time away from larger cities. Remote working, made increasingly possible by the pandemic's work from home (WFH) compulsions, has made life in cities unattractive for many. A 2021 survey by NoBroker.com, a real estate platform, shows that 82 per cent of their users want a second home away from the city. The CII-Anarock Consumer Sentiment Survey, conducted between January and June 2021 among 4,965 participants, also points to a growing consumer interest in greener environments. Around 68 per cent of the respondents expressed a desire to own property in peripheral or suburban areas; 72 per cent designated walking trails as a must-have; and 68 per cent expressed a keenness to have adequate open green spaces. Another survey, conducted late last year by Savills India, a global property consultant, pointed out that 70 per cent of their respondents want a second home in the next two years, which they plan on using for at least the next five years. Most of this interest is being driven by concerns for children, elders and a desire for a safer, healthier way of life.

"During the pandemic, people moved out of their homes and did short-term stays at Airbnb properties. It made them realise that remote working is possibly here to stay and they could consider a life away from the city more permanently. People are now thinking of living in towns at a drive of two to three hours from the city," says Shobhan Kothari, architect and partner at ADND, an architectural firm in Mumbai. He adds that for his clients in Maharashtra, the most desired destination for a second home was Lonavala for a long time. "Alibaug was known, but was relatively less popular. But now, Alibaug has become a popular choice for a second home. There are also towns like Karjat that are becoming popular," says Kothari.